

2 Non-Cognitivism

Part 1: Classical Theory and Linguistic Evidence

2.1 Classical non-cognitivism

Pleasure is good.

How should we understand that statement? The most straightforward answer is the cognitivist one. Ethical cognitivism is the view that evaluative statements like 'Pleasure is good' assert propositions, which can be either true or false, just like the statements 'The sky is red' and 'Weasels are mammals'. Given this, the most straightforward account of what the word 'good' is doing in the sentence is this: there is a property, goodness, which the word refers to, and the sentence ascribes that property to pleasure.¹

Non-cognitivists deny that 'good' denotes a property, and they deny that 'Pleasure is good' asserts anything in the way that 'Weasels are mammals' does. It is thus up to them to give us an alternative account of the meaning of 'Pleasure is good'. Two main non-cognitivist accounts have arisen: emotivism and prescriptivism.

Emotivism holds that the primary function of 'x is good' is to express a positive emotion or attitude (not a belief) that the speaker has about x. Thus, 'x is good' is like, 'Hooray for x!' When one says, 'Pleasure is good', one is not asserting that one has this feeling; one is just expressing the feeling. Compare: when one says 'Ow!', one is not asserting that one feels pain; one is just expressing one's pain. One difference between assertion and expression is that an assertion, such as 'I am in pain', is either true or false, whereas a mere expression, such as 'Ow!', is neither true nor false. Thus, emotivists have traditionally denied that 'x is good' is either true or false.²

Prescriptivism holds that the function of '\$x\$ is good' is, roughly, to tell people what to do. Thus, it is like 'Pursue \$x!\$' or 'Approve of \$x!\$'. Note that 'Pursue \$x!\$' is not an assertion and is neither true nor false. Similarly, '\$x\$ is good' is neither true nor false on a simple prescriptivist view. Admittedly, moral statements differ from other imperatives in some important ways, so '\$x\$ is good' is not exactly like 'Pursue \$x\$'. For instance, it seems that moral imperatives have a kind of universality: in putting forward a moral imperative, one endorses some sort of general rule applicable to all people, including oneself, which is not true of ordinary, non-moral imperatives.

Other, more subtle forms of non-cognitivism exist. Perhaps evaluative statements have both emotive and prescriptive functions. Perhaps they serve as much to influence the audience's feelings as to express the speaker's. Perhaps they express some other non-cognitive mental state, besides emotion and desire. What is common to all the non-cognitivist views is, again, that they hold that the primary function of evaluative statements is something other than asserting propositions. The arguments of this chapter will support cognitivism against any form of non-cognitivism.

2.2 How can we tell if cognitivism is true?

I begin with a simple but crucial observation for the debate about ethical cognitivism. The observation is that the issue at hand is empirical. Cognitivism and non-cognitivism are competing claims about the current meaning and function of evaluative language. Non-cognitivists are not advocating a change in how we use language—that would just amount to an effort to change the subject. They are trying to describe how evaluative language actually works. And claims of this sort are empirical. Imagine someone maintaining that the word 'duck' means 'four-legged animal'. This hypothesis has testable predictions: for example, that typical English speakers (competent in the use of these words) would not call anything a 'four-legged animal' unless they would also call it a 'duck'. We can test this prediction by, for example, asking some competent speakers whether they would call a cat a 'four-legged animal', and also whether they would call it a 'duck'.

That is a simple example. Refuting non-cognitivism will not be so simple, for non-cognitivism is a more abstract thesis which need not involve the claim that 'good' is synonymous with any other expression. Nevertheless, the point remains that cognitivism and non-cognitivism, as claims about meanings, ought to have testable predictions about the way we use evaluative language. We can see whether people use evaluative statements more like how they use typical proposition-expressing sentences, or more like how they use typical non-proposition-expressing sentences. We will consider this in the next section.

Not everyone frames the issue this way. And admittedly there are other considerations relevant to assessing ethical non-cognitivism besides that of whether we treat ethical statements like assertions. Usually, philosophers rely on broader theoretical considerations, such as the supposed desirability, in general, of maintaining a 'naturalistic worldview' (avoiding 'weird' things that scientists don't talk about), the alleged untenability of alternative metaethical theories, and the ability of non-cognitivism to explain why we are motivated to act in the ways we consider moral.

The appeal to these broad theoretical considerations is methodologically inferior to the kind of appeal I shall make to how we use ethical language. Why? Because the linguistic evidence is by far the more objective evidence. Here I am using 'objective' in an epistemological sense (not the sense discussed in section 1.1): objective evidence is, roughly, evidence whose existence and relevance can be ascertained in a relatively straightforward manner; it does not require difficult exercises of judgment, weighing of competing considerations, resolution of complex philosophical issues, or the establishment of an overall worldview, to determine whether the evidence exists or what conclusion it supports.

For example, A. J. Ayer argued for non-cognitivism by appealing to the premises

- (1) that ethical statements are unverifiable, and
- (2) that a statement has cognitive meaning only if it can be verified.

In short, Ayer cited the unverifiability of ethical statements as evidence against cognitivism.[8] This evidence is highly subjective, for in order to determine whether ethical statements are really unverifiable, we must first resolve such philosophical questions as whether intuition counts as a means of knowledge, whether facts about our attitudes and conventions count as verification for evaluative statements, and whether evaluative statements ever help explain non-evaluative facts. Furthermore, in order to accept the unverifiability of evaluative statements as evidence for non-cognitivism, one must first accept Ayer's logical positivist philosophy about what 'meaning' is. All of these are highly contentious, complex, philosophical issues. My point is not that these issues cannot be resolved, nor that arguments involving controversial philosophical claims are never appropriate. My point is that it would be foolish to rely on evidence of that kind when straightforward, objective tests of a thesis are available.

My methodology is roughly this. There are some sentences that are uncontroversially assertive—sentences that ethical cognitivists and non-cognitivists alike would take to assert propositions. There are other sentences that are uncontroversially non-assertive. We can identify features of the former that do not belong to the latter, and see whether evaluative statements have those features. The evidence I shall cite is straightforwardly available to any competent English speaker. Nor can its relevance be easily disputed. Doubtless some will dispute whether the evidence is sufficient to reject non-cognitivism, but even non-cognitivists admit that it counts against their theory.⁹

2.3 The linguistic evidence for cognitivism

There are several features characteristic of proposition-expressing sentences, all of which evaluative statements have:¹⁰

- (a) Evaluative statements take the form of declarative sentences, rather than, say, imperatives, questions, or interjections. 'Pleasure is good' has the same grammatical form as 'Weasels are mammals'. Sentences of this form are normally used to make factual assertions.¹¹ In contrast, the paradigms of non-cognitive utterances, such as 'Hurray for x' and 'Pursue x', are not declarative sentences.
- (b) Moral predicates can be transformed into abstract nouns, suggesting that they are intended to refer to properties; we talk about 'goodness', 'rightness', and so on, as in 'I am not questioning the act's prudence, but its rightness'.
- (c) We ascribe to evaluations the same sort of properties as other propositions. You can say, 'It is true that I have done some wrong things in the past', 'It is false that contraception is murder', and 'It is possible that abortion is wrong'. 'True', 'false', and 'possible' are predicates that we apply only to propositions. No one would say, 'It is true that ouch', 'It is false that shut the door', or 'It is possible that hurray'.
- (d) All the propositional attitude verbs can be prefixed to evaluative statements. We can say, 'Jon believes that the war was just', 'I hope I did the right thing', 'I wish we had a better President', and 'I wonder whether I did the right thing'. In contrast, no one would say, 'Jon believes that ouch', 'I hope that hurray for the Broncos', 'I wish that shut the door', or 'I wonder whether please pass the salt'. The obvious explanation is that such mental states as believing, hoping, wishing, and wondering are by their nature propositional: To hope is to hope that something is the case, to wonder is to wonder whether

something is the case, and so on. That is why one cannot hope that one did the right thing unless there is a proposition—something that might be the case—corresponding to the expression 'one did the right thing'.

(e) Evaluative statements can be transformed into yes/no questions: One can assert 'Cinnamon ice cream is good', but one can also ask, 'Is cinnamon ice cream good?' No analogous questions can be formed from imperatives or emotional expressions: 'Shut the door?' and 'Hurray for the Broncos?' lack clear meaning. The obvious explanation is that a yes/no question requires a proposition; it asks whether something is the case.

A prescriptivist non-cognitivist might interpret some evaluative yes/no questions as requests for instruction, as in 'Should I shut off the oven now?' But other questions would defy interpretation along these lines, including evaluative questions about other people's behavior or about the past—'Was it wrong for Emperor Nero to kill Agrippina?' is not a request for instruction.

(f) One can issue imperatives and emotional expressions directed at things that are characterized morally. If non-cognitivism is true, what do these mean: 'Do the right thing.' 'Hurray for virtue!' Even more puzzlingly for the non-cognitivist, you can imagine appropriate contexts for such remarks as, 💎💎💎 'We shouldn't be doing this, but I don't care; let's do it anyway!'. This is perfectly intelligible, but it would be unintelligible if 'We shouldn't be doing this' either expressed an aversive emotion towards the proposed action or issued an imperative not to do it.

(g) In some sentences, evaluative terms appear without the speaker's either endorsing or impugning anything, yet the terms are used in their normal senses. This is known as the *Frege-Geach problem* and forms the basis for perhaps the best-known objection to non-cognitivism.¹² Consider two examples.

Example 1:

'If adultery is wrong, then God will punish Clinton.' This sentence delivers no verdict on adultery; it says neither that adultery is wrong nor that it is not. So 'wrong' is not used there to express a negative psychological reaction to adultery, nor is it used to issue an anti-adultery imperative, nor to influence the audience's feelings against adultery. It is difficult to see how the non-cognitivist could explain the meaning of 'adultery is wrong' in this context. Indeed, since a statement of the form 'If p then q' generally requires a proposition to be plugged in for p, it seems that if 'adultery is wrong' expresses no proposition, then the whole sentence is nonsense—like 'If please pass the salt, then the potatoes need more salt' or 'If hurray for the Broncos, then the Broncos are going to win!'¹³

Example 2:

Aboard the sinking Titanic, the captain says: 'There's a right way to handle this situation'. Since he doesn't say what the right way to handle the situation is, he is not expressing a positive emotion towards anything, trying to influence anyone's attitudes, or telling anyone to do anything. Yet 'right' is evidently being used in its normal sense nonetheless. This is shown by the fact that the captain could sensibly continue as follows: 'And that way is to draw straws to see who may get on the life boats'. Although he has now endorsed drawing straws, he obviously has not changed the meaning of his initial use of 'right'.

A tempting move is to let evaluative terms refer to emotions or acts of issuing commands when they appear in these contexts. For instance, we might read 'If adultery is wrong, then God will punish Clinton' as meaning something like, 'If adultery conflicts with God's commands, then God will punish Clinton'. Here is why that won't help the non-cognitivist: Does the sentence 'Adultery is wrong', when stated by itself, mean that adultery conflicts with God's will?

Suppose the non-cognitivist says 'yes'. Then 'Adultery is wrong' expresses a proposition, which is either true or false: it is either true or false that adultery conflicts with God's commands. Our erstwhile non-cognitivist has thus abandoned non-cognitivism in favor of subjectivism: it is subjectivists who say that evaluative statements express propositions about someone's attitudes. We will critique subjectivism in the following chapter; for now, the important point is that this is not a way of preserving non-cognitivism.

Suppose, then, that the non-cognitivist says 'no'. Now consider the following deductive inference that someone might make:

If adultery is wrong, God will punish Clinton.

Adultery is wrong.

Therefore, God will punish Clinton.

Our non-cognitivist is now committed to claiming that 'adultery is wrong' has a different meaning in the first premise from its meaning in the second. For he has said that in the first premise, 'adultery is wrong' means that adultery conflicts with God's commands. But in the second premise it does not mean this; instead, it just expresses some non-cognitive attitude. If so, the above argument should strike us as illogical, as committing an equivocation. But this is not the case—we can see that the first two statements entail the third. This can only be the case if 'wrong' has the same meaning in both premises.¹⁴

The same applies to any other attempt to save non-cognitivism by letting evaluative terms refer to someone's emotions or commands. Thus, suppose the non-cognitivist says 'There's a right way to handle this situation' means 'There's a way to handle this situation that I would approve of'. Now ask: Does 'x is right', by itself, mean 'I would approve of x'? If the non-cognitivist says 'yes', then he has abandoned non-cognitivism in favor of subjectivism. 'I would approve of x' is a factual claim, which is either true or false, not a non-cognitive utterance.

If the non-cognitivist says 'no', then he must say that 'right' shifts its meaning between the following two sentences—

There is a right way to handle this situation.

The right way to handle this situation is to draw straws to decide who gets on the lifeboats.

—since 'right way' in the first sentence means 'way that I would approve of', but 'right way' in the second sentence does not mean this but instead functions to express a non-cognitive emotional attitude towards the drawing of straws. If so, then the second statement does not entail the first. But that's false: 'right' obviously has the same meaning in both sentences, and the latter sentence obviously entails the first.

Let us summarize the arguments given under points (b)-(g) above. Here is a strong reading of the argument against non-cognitivism:

1. Each of the following sentences makes sense:

I am questioning the act's rightness.

It is true that pleasure is good.

I hope I did the right thing.

Is abortion wrong?

Do the right thing.

If pleasure is good, then chocolate is good.

Something is good.

2. None of those sentences would make sense if non-cognitivism were true.

3. Therefore, non-cognitivism is false.

Each of the sentences listed in premise (1) creates a distinct objection to non-cognitivism; the non-cognitivist must deal with *all* of the examples in order to defend his position.

The justification for premise (1) is that the sentences listed, and others like them, would strike any ordinary English speaker as making sense; indeed, they are not even slightly odd. Some sentences of these kinds would even be regarded as indisputably true by nearly everyone. Virtually no one would dispute the truth of my claim that *I believe pleasure is good*, or that *If abortion is wrong, then fetuses have rights*. The *prima facie* case for holding each of those sentences to be intelligible is about as strong as that for holding anything to be intelligible.

Premise (2) seems plausible given the non-cognitivist's thesis that 'Pleasure is good' means something like 'Hurray for pleasure' or 'Pursue pleasure'; neither of these views provides a basis for any straightforward understanding of any of the sentences mentioned in (1). In some cases (as in 'I hope I did the right thing'), it is hard to even think of a first-pass paraphrase of the sentences based on the non-cognitivist's theory. In other cases, one can think of a first-pass paraphrase, but it is evidently a nonsense sentence (like 'If hurray for pleasure, then hurray for chocolate').

(3) follows from (1) and (2). I assume the non-cognitivist would want to attack premise (2), since attacking (1) seems hopeless. We will consider attacks on premise (2), at least for some of the kinds of sentences listed, in the following sections of this chapter.

Now, here is a weaker interpretation of the problem for non-cognitivism. On this interpretation, the argument does not conclusively refute non-cognitivism; however, it has force against non-cognitivism even if the non-cognitivist can find a way to make sense of the sentences listed under premise (1) above.

4. If non-cognitivism were true, then it would be more likely that the following sentences would strike us odd, malformed, or confused, than it would be if cognitivism were true:

I am questioning the act's rightness. It is true that pleasure is good. I hope I did the right thing. Is abortion wrong? Do the right thing. If pleasure is good, then chocolate is good. Something is good.

5. None of those sentences strike us as odd, malformed, or confused.

6. Therefore, our reaction to those sentences is evidence in favor of cognitivism over non-cognitivism.

We can see that (4) is true by contrasting paradigmatically non-cognitive utterances. There is, to my knowledge, no uncontroversially non-cognitive expression or sentence from which one could form sentences analogous to any of those listed under (4). 'Hurray for the Broncos' and 'Pass the salt' do not give rise to sentences like those. So we must at least say that, if non-cognitivism does not entail that we should find the listed sentences unintelligible, it at least leads one to expect this. Imagine how things would stand if the sentences listed did strike us as odd, malformed, or confused. If most competent English speakers found 'I believe pleasure is good' unintelligible, just as we in fact find 'I believe please pass the salt' unintelligible, then obviously non-cognitivists could and would cite this as powerful evidence for their thesis. Conversely, if we do not find 'I believe pleasure is good' to be unintelligible, then this fact is evidence against non-cognitivism.[15]

Nor should one underestimate the strength of this evidence. The non-cognitivist makes a claim about actual meanings, but all of the reasonably direct and objective evidence, drawn from the way we use ethical language, points towards cognitivism. Every linguistic test that would differentiate uncontroversial examples of cognitive utterances from uncontroversial examples of non-cognitive utterances delivers the result that evaluative statements fit in with the cognitive. Evaluative statements act in every way like factual claims.

Hitherto, non-cognitivists have rested their case on the sorts of broad philosophical arguments that I have previously argued to be methodologically inferior to the reliance on linguistic intuitions and facts about language usage. Despite my methodological objection, I do not plan to ignore their arguments; they will be taken up in later chapters. They can generally be viewed as arguments against the workability of other metaethical positions, particularly moral realism. If the other metaethical positions should really prove to be unworkable, then we would have reason to revisit non-cognitivism. But for now we should reject it.